

# Colour in Every Skin Tone

*Undertone, the shade spectrum the industry ignored for decades, and the colour theory that corrects honestly*

---

## Learning Objectives

- Determine a client's undertone accurately, independent of her surface depth of colour
- Explain why a narrow foundation shade range historically failed deep skin tones, and what changed
- Use complementary colour theory to correct redness, dullness, and discolouration honestly
- Match foundation and concealer shade and undertone together, never one without the other

Depth and undertone are two different questions

A foundation match fails for one of two reasons: the wrong depth (too light or too dark) or the wrong undertone (too pink, too yellow, too ashen) — and the two errors are frequently confused. Depth describes how light or dark a skin tone is. Undertone describes the underlying hue beneath that depth — warm (yellow, peach, golden), cool (pink, red, blue), or neutral (a balanced mix of both). Two clients can share an identical depth of colour and require entirely different undertone formulas.

Reading undertone accurately

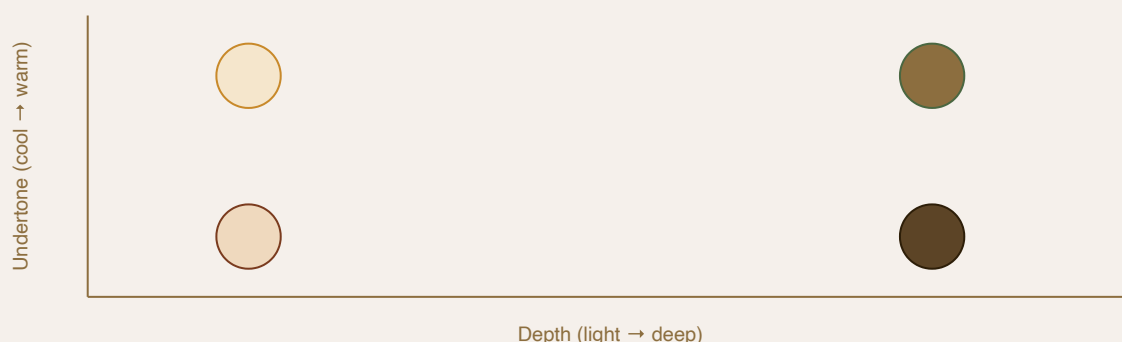
- **The vein test.** Veins on the inner wrist appear greenish under warm undertones, bluish or purple under cool undertones, and a mix of both under neutral undertones. Useful, but never conclusive alone.

- **The jewellery test.** Gold generally flatters warmer undertones; silver generally flatters cooler undertones; both flatter neutral undertones roughly equally.
- **The white-paper test.** Held against bare, makeup-free skin in natural light, skin with a warm undertone appears to have a yellow or golden cast; skin with a cool undertone appears pink or rosy by contrast.
- **The most reliable test.** A small swipe of two or three shade-matched foundations along the jawline, checked in natural daylight — the shade that visually disappears into the skin, rather than sitting on top of it, has the correct undertone match.

A gap the industry left unaddressed for decades

For most of the modern cosmetics industry's history, foundation shade ranges clustered heavily around lighter depths, offering only a handful of options — often poorly matched even in undertone — for deeper skin tones. This was never a matter of pigment science being impossible; it was a matter of an industry building for a narrow slice of its actual customer base. The gap became impossible to ignore publicly in 2017, when a major beauty brand's 40-shade foundation launch exposed, by direct comparison, just how limited the rest of the industry's ranges had been — deep-toned shades sold out first and fastest, demonstrating a demand that had simply gone unmet. The lesson for a practitioner is not a history trivia point. It is a working standard: never train your eye only on the lighter half of the shade spectrum, and never let a limited kit be the reason a client is told, even implicitly, that her skin tone is difficult to match.

◆ Figure 2.1 · Depth and Undertone Are Two Axes



Depth and undertone move independently — a full kit must offer range on both axes, not just one.

Colour correcting, by the wheel

Colour correctors work by applying the colour opposite a discolouration on the colour wheel, neutralising it before foundation is applied over the top.

- **Green** neutralises redness — active breakouts, rosacea, irritation.
- **Peach or orange** neutralises blue- or purple-toned dark circles and discolouration, and reads more naturally on deeper skin tones than the paler lavender correctors marketed almost exclusively for years.
- **Lavender or purple** neutralises yellow-toned dullness, most visible on fair to medium skin.
- **Yellow** neutralises purple-toned bruising or deep under-eye darkness once the base correction is set.

Apply correctors sparingly and blend the edges fully — a visible colour corrector under foundation is a more common and more noticeable error than the discolouration it was meant to hide.

## Key Terms

0

[object Object]

1

[object Object]

2

[object Object]

## Practical Activity · The Undertone Audit

Determine your own (or a model's) undertone using at least three tests from this module. Note whether they agreed. Then shade-match against at least three foundation

options spanning a wide depth range, and record which disappeared most convincingly into the skin. **Keep this record for your consultation practice in Module Ten.**